

A MAESTRO RESOURCE FOR PARENTS

THE PATHWAY GUIDE.

Navigating the journey from grassroots to professional football — what clubs actually look for, what happens at every age, and how to support your child the right way.

WELCOME

WHY THIS GUIDE EXISTS.

You've seen it in training, in the garden, in the way they can't stop thinking about the game. But knowing your child has talent and knowing how to help them reach the highest levels are two very different things — and that gap is exactly what this guide is here to close.

Inside these pages, you'll find the same frameworks professional clubs, elite scouts, and national associations use to identify and develop players — drawn from the **FA's Elite Player Performance Plan (EPPP)**, **UEFA's player development guidelines**, and the **Professional Football Scouts Association (PFSA)** — distilled into something you can actually use.

Whether your child is 7 and just discovering the game, or 16 and knocking on the door of an academy, this guide will show you what clubs are looking for, what your child can do to stand out, and — just as importantly — how you can support them the right way.

"The best thing a parent can do is create the environment. The player creates the player." — a shared principle across FA, PFSA & UEFA development frameworks.

What this guide covers:

- **How clubs really identify talent** — the four-corner model and what scouts are actually watching
- **Age-by-age development pathways** — what's expected at every stage
- **Position-specific guidance** — what to develop for your child's role
- **Solo training ideas** — practical work outside of coached sessions
- **The parent's role** — supporting without hindering
- **Getting noticed** — trials, showcases, and how the pathway actually works

SECTION 1

HOW CLUBS REALLY IDENTIFY TALENT.

Talent identification isn't just about who scores the most goals. Clubs and national associations assess players across four connected areas — commonly known as the "Four Corner Model," a framework widely used across English football's talent pathway.

TECHNICAL

Ball control, passing, first touch, finishing — the on-the-ball skills most parents naturally focus on. Necessary, but only one quarter of the picture.

PHYSICAL

Speed, strength, agility, and endurance — relative to the player's own stage of growth, not compared unfairly to early developers.

PSYCHOLOGICAL

Decision-making speed, composure under pressure, coachability, and resilience after mistakes — often the biggest differentiator at higher levels.

SOCIAL

Communication, leadership, relationships with teammates and coaches — how a player fits into and lifts a team environment.

What this means in practice: a technically gifted player who struggles to make quick decisions, take feedback, or communicate with teammates is a harder recruit than a slightly less flashy player who's strong across all four corners. Scouts are trained to watch the whole picture — not just the moments with the ball.

The FA's EPPP structures the professional academy system around three phases: the **Foundation Phase** (broadly ages 5-11), the **Youth Development Phase** (ages 12-16), and the **Professional Development Phase** (ages 17-21) — each with different priorities, covered next.

SECTION 2

AGE-BY-AGE DEVELOPMENT PATHWAYS.

What's genuinely expected — and genuinely useful to focus on — shifts significantly as your child moves through the pathway.

U5 – U11 – FOUNDATION PHASE

Focus: Love of the game, technical foundation, multi-sport movement

- Ball mastery and enjoyment come first — technical repetition disguised as fun
 - Encourage playing multiple sports, not early specialisation
 - Small-sided games build more decision-making reps than 11-a-side at this age
 - Parent's role: enthusiasm, encouragement, and zero pressure around results
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U12 – U16 – YOUTH DEVELOPMENT PHASE

Focus: Technical mastery, tactical identity, mental strength — the most heavily scouted window

- High technical standard under real pressure — clean touches, weight of pass, execution
 - Developing a clear positional identity and understanding of role within a team system
 - Physical development accelerates unevenly — growth spurts affect players very differently
 - This is the period elite clubs scout most intensely across grassroots and academy football
 - Parent's role: stay calm and grounded, prioritise rest/recovery/nutrition, avoid comparing to other players
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U17 – U21 – PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT PHASE

Focus: Transition to senior football, professional habits, performance under real stakes

- Consistent senior-level physical output — speed, power, and endurance become genuinely comparable to adults
- Advanced tactical understanding across multiple systems and roles
- Professional habits matter as much as talent: punctuality, nutrition, recovery routines
- Parent's role shifts to emotional support rather than footballing advice — this is where reputable, FA-licensed representation (if relevant) enters the conversation

SECTION 3

POSITION-SPECIFIC GUIDANCE.

Every position has its own priorities. Here's what typically matters most for each.

GOALKEEPER

Shot-stopping fundamentals, distribution under pressure, communication and organisation of the defensive line, composure in 1v1 situations.

CENTRE-BACK

Positioning and reading the game before physical duels, composure playing out from the back, aerial ability, communication.

FULL-BACK

Recovery pace, 1v1 defending, overlapping runs and crossing, decision-making on when to attack vs. stay disciplined.

CENTRAL MIDFIELD

Scanning before receiving, range of passing, tempo control, defensive work rate, game intelligence under pressure.

WINGER

1v1 dribbling ability, end product (crosses/final ball), pace in behind, willingness to track back defensively.

STRIKER

Movement and timing of runs, finishing with both feet, hold-up play, pressing triggers and work rate off the ball.

Younger players (under 12) benefit from playing multiple positions rather than specialising early — it builds a more complete footballing brain and keeps options open as their body and game develop.

SECTION 4

SOLO TRAINING IDEAS.

Time on the ball outside of coached sessions compounds fast. None of this needs special equipment — a ball, a wall, and some cones is genuinely enough.

- 1 Wall Passing**
Two-touch passing against a wall, both feet, increasing distance and pace over time. Builds first touch and passing weight simultaneously — 10-15 minutes is enough to make a real difference.
- 2 Cone Ball Mastery**
Set 4-6 cones in a line, weave through with close control using both feet, varying the surface of the foot used. Increase speed as control improves.
- 3 Juggling for Touch**
Not just a party trick — consistent juggling builds first-touch softness and body control. Start with thigh/foot only, build toward using both feet and head.
- 4 Weak Foot Focus**
Dedicate 5 minutes of every session purely to the weaker foot — passing, striking, first touch. This is one of the fastest, most visible improvements a player can make.
- 5 Video Self-Review**
Record a session or match clip and watch it back together — not to criticise, but to help the player see their own decision-making. Ask "what did you see there?" rather than telling them what to do.

SECTION 5

THE PARENT'S ROLE.

This is, genuinely, the section elite coaches and scouts say matters most — and the one least talked about.

Be the calm in the car. The ride home after a game or session is one of the most influential moments in a young player's development. Resist the urge to analyse the match. A simple "I loved watching you play" does more for a player's long-term relationship with the game than any tactical breakdown.

Coach the coach, not the player. Constant sideline instruction — even well-meaning — creates a player who plays for approval rather than instinct. Trust the coaching your child is receiving in sessions; use match time to just watch and enjoy.

Praise effort and decision-making, not just outcomes. A great decision that didn't come off (a difficult pass that gets intercepted) is often better development than a lucky outcome from a poor decision. Reinforce the process.

Protect against burnout. Enthusiasm for extra training is great — but rest, recovery, and a life outside football all directly support long-term development, not detract from it.

The behaviours elite clubs love to see in families:

Calm and supportive on the sideline. Trusting the coaching process. Prioritising their child's enjoyment of the game alongside development. Being easy, positive, and low-drama to work with — clubs notice this as much as they notice the player.

SECTION 6

GETTING NOTICED.

How the pathway actually works, beyond just "being good enough."

Trials and showcases. Most academy entries come through open trials, scouted grassroots performances, or invitation-only showcase events. Being aware of and prepared for these opportunities matters as much as the underlying ability.

A clean video reel matters. A short, well-edited highlight video — showing decision-making and repeated actions, not just one lucky moment — is increasingly how players first get noticed, especially for showcases and trials outside your immediate area.

Consistency beats a single great game. Scouts who follow a player do so over multiple viewings. A standout performance helps, but what actually gets a player signed is consistent evidence across the four corners, over time.

A guided pathway helps. This is exactly where working with a coach who understands the professional identification process — not just coaching technique — makes a genuine difference: knowing what's actually being assessed, when, and how to prepare for it.

READY FOR THE NEXT STEP?

MAESTRO's coaching is built around exactly this pathway — FA Talent ID assessment, video analysis, and a development plan built around your child specifically.

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